managed to score 193 runs from 143 balls in the final. More importantly, as a team of eager 19-year-olds, we secured a notable tournament win in India.

Were we hailed as stars of the future?

Did we feel like stars of the future?

If that was the case, I was blissfully unaware of such expectations. In my mind, I just wanted to play for Northerns. The 2003/04 season hurried towards its conclusion, but our hopes of winning a trophy were dashed as we were defeated by Gauteng in a Standard Bank Cup semifinal at the Wanderers.

Then the telephone rang yet again.

'AB,' said Dave Nosworthy, 'would you like to play in Northern Ireland?'

'Where?'

'Northern Ireland ... there's a club called Carrickfergus and they're looking for an overseas player.'

I told my parents. They encouraged me to go.

Why not?

I was scarcely 20 years old, eager to gain experience, eager to play cricket, eager to hit the ball. So I flew from Johannesburg to London and on to Belfast, and was met at the airport by someone apparently in a rush. There was no time to lose, he said, so we drove up the M5, on to the A2, on towards 'Carrick' on the northern shore of the Belfast Lough, barely 30 kilometres across the water from Scotland.

'What's the hurry?' I asked.

'The match has already started,' he replied.

We drove straight to the ground where Carrickfergus CC had won the toss and decided to bat against Belfast Harlequins. I was told to change, get padded up and be ready to bat at No. 3. The first wicket fell a few minutes later and, two hours after arriving in the country, I walked out to bat for my new club and introduced myself to my teammate in the middle.